

THE RECOMBINATION GAP

Why Futures Feel Unequal

A Structural Account of Memory, Networks, and Divergent Prospection

DRAVEN

DRAVEN — THE DECENTRALIZED EPISTEMOLOGIST

Independent imprint for coordination-infrastructure research across blockchain systems and human epistemics — building toward secured, uncensored value at scale.

For Unspoken Indians —
the first thought behind this work.

*For anyone who has felt something in their own life that suffocates,
without ever finding the name for it —*

*this book will not name it for you. But it will show you, precisely, why the
shape of what felt possible was smaller than it needed to be.*

*“The gap is not manufactured. It is exposed — and what it exposes is a difference
in the material available for a mind to build with.”*

— working thesis

Abstract

This work advances a structural account of why two people, situated at the same present moment, can hold unequal images of their own achievable futures. It argues that prospection — the mind's construction of an imagined future — is not predictive but reconstructive, drawing on the same fragment-based machinery documented in memory research (Bartlett, 1932; Schacter and Addis, 2007). The central claim, termed the **recombination gap**, holds that the specificity and perceived achievability of an imagined future is bounded by the size and composition of a person's available experiential fragment inventory — not by intelligence, ambition, or effort.

Coordination networks are shown to alter which fragments circulate and at what resolution, without altering the underlying scarcity mechanism itself; imported fragments arrive disproportionately stripped of the cost and friction data that produced them, biasing prospection toward underestimating the achievable (Verduyn et al., 2015; Kahneman, 2011). Supporting evidence is drawn from opportunity-mobility research (Chetty et al., 2018; Bell et al., 2019) at a scale sufficient to treat the claim as measurable rather than anecdotal.

The argument is deliberately bounded. Chapter 6 identifies and rejects an adjacent claim — that this mechanism explains the meaning of existence — as unsupported by the evidence assembled here. The method throughout is Contact Epistemology: a claim is retained only where it survives testing against structure, mechanism, and the existing empirical record.

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Prologue

Picture two people at the same clock-second. One stands on a street in Newark, New Jersey, phone in hand, half-watching a stranger's renovated kitchen scroll past on a five-inch screen. The other stands on a ridge in Nagaland, watching smoke rise from a cooking fire she can name by smell alone. Ask each of them, right now, to picture themselves in five years. Neither answer is wrong. Neither is lazy, or unambitious, or limited by raw ability. Both are running the exact same piece of biological machinery, under the exact same rules. What differs is not the machine. It is what the machine has been fed.

This book exists because that difference is usually described in the wrong vocabulary — as culture, as mindset, as privilege, as motivation — words that gesture at the gap without ever opening it up. What follows is an attempt to open it up: to trace, mechanism by mechanism, what actually produces unequal futures between two people standing at the same moment, and to stop, deliberately, at the exact point where the evidence runs out.

Author's Note

I build under the name Draven. That is a structural choice, not a gimmick: the argument in this book has to stand on the mechanism and the evidence, not on a face, a credential, or an institution behind it. This is Contact Epistemology in practice — the working position that a claim is verified against structure and physical or mechanistic consequence, not against who is making it or what authority backs it. If a reader would trust this book more with a university seal on the cover, that reaction is itself a data point about how most claims get accepted, and it is the exact reflex this book is built to route around.

The recombination gap did not arrive by summarizing a stack of existing papers. It was built the way most Contact Epistemology work is built: as a live, unscripted line of reasoning about memory, existence, and the specific gap between a life in Newark and a life in Nagaland, pushed and revised until the parts that could not survive scrutiny were cut. The citations gathered in these chapters were added afterward, to check the reasoning against the existing record, not to generate the reasoning in the first place. Where the independent line of thought converged with established research — Bartlett, Schacter and Addis, Kahneman, Chetty — that convergence is the actual proof of work. It means the mechanism was findable from first principles, not borrowed from authority.

The expectation for the reader is the same discipline the book holds for itself: test it, don't accept it. Chapter 6.2 exists because the argument was pushed toward a claim about the meaning of existence, and it did not hold. That failure is named inside the book rather than quietly removed, because a framework that never shows its own discipline failing anything is not a framework — it is a sales pitch. Nothing here is asking to be believed on the strength of the name on the cover. The structure and the evidence are the argument. Anything in these pages that does not survive a reader's own contact with reality should be discarded exactly as readily as the meaning-claim was discarded in Chapter 6.

Readers looking for a metaphysics of existence will not find one here. Readers looking for a precise, testable account of why two people, standing in the same present moment, can hold structurally unequal futures — will, and should push on it exactly as hard as it was pushed while being built.

Preface

The question that opened this inquiry was simple to ask and hard to answer cleanly: what is the actual difference between the felt future of a person living in a dense, networked, developed environment, and the felt future of a person living in a tribal community with a fundamentally different relationship to land, time, and coordination? Not a difference in worth. A difference in structure.

The first temptation was to reach for the network itself — the internet, APIs, coordination infrastructure — as the manufacturer of that gap. That temptation does not survive scrutiny. The gap predates the network. What the network changes is something narrower and more precise: which fragments of experience are available to a mind when it tries to build an image of its own future.

That narrower claim is the spine of this book. It is deliberately smaller than a theory of everything, and deliberately larger than a single essay. What follows is the case for it, built one mechanism at a time.

PART I

The Mechanism

Prospection Is Reconstruction, Not Storage

This chapter establishes the argument's first load-bearing claim: prospection — the mental construction of a possible future — is not a predictive or retrieval process but a reconstructive one, assembled from discrete experiential fragments rather than retrieved as a stored whole. The claim is demonstrated in two parts. Section 1.1 establishes that memory itself, the raw material prospection draws on, has no fixed archive and is rebuilt at each act of retrieval. Section 1.2 identifies the specific neural mechanism — the default mode network — that performs this reconstruction for both remembered and imagined events, using a shared substrate. Everything that follows in this book depends on this claim holding as literal mechanism, not as metaphor.

1.1 Why Memory Has No Fixed Archive

The intuitive model of memory — information goes in, gets filed, gets pulled back out unchanged — is wrong, and it has been wrong in the research literature for over a century. Frederic Bartlett's 1932 study *Remembering* had participants recall an unfamiliar folk story, “The War of the Ghosts,” at increasing intervals. The recollections did not degrade like a fading photograph. They transformed — unfamiliar details were dropped, the story was reshaped to fit the participant's existing cultural expectations, and each retelling drifted further from the original while the participant's confidence in it stayed high. Bartlett's conclusion was that remembering is “imaginative reconstruction,” not reproduction.

The mechanism is concrete enough to demonstrate directly: asked to recall a specific childhood birthday, a person does not retrieve a stored file. They report a room, a cake, a remembered sentence — details assembled convincingly enough that the reconstruction is experienced as retrieval. The confidence is real. The archive it implies is not.

Modern neuroscience gives that reconstruction a physical location. Memory researcher Daniel Schacter and his colleague Donna Rose Addis proposed what is now called the **constructive episodic simulation hypothesis**: the hippocampus and its associated network do not store whole episodes. They store fragments — sensory details, spatial layouts, emotional tags — and reassemble them on demand. This is why memory is error-prone in a specific, patterned way: not random noise, but systematic recombination, pulling in fragments from adjacent events, plausible details that were never actually present. The errors are not a bug in an otherwise

faithful system. They are the signature of how the system actually works.

Analogy: a fixed archive is a photograph in a drawer — open the drawer, the photograph is unchanged. A reconstructive memory is closer to a jazz musician playing a tune from memory — the chord structure and a few motifs are stable, but the actual notes are re-performed each time, shaped by who is in the room and what was just played a moment before. You would never mistake a re-performance for the original recording. Your brain makes exactly that mistake about your own memories, every day, without noticing.

1.2 The Default Mode Network as a Recombination Engine

The chapter's central claim needs a mechanism, not just an analogy, and neuroimaging supplies one. In a series of studies beginning around 2007, Addis, Schacter, and colleagues used fMRI to compare brain activity while subjects remembered a past event versus imagined a specific future event. The overlap was extensive: the hippocampus, medial prefrontal cortex, and posterior cingulate — collectively part of what is called the default mode network — activated in both conditions. Critically, imagining a future event showed *additional* activity in regions associated with recombining elements into a new configuration, consistent with the idea that future simulation is memory's machinery run in a generative rather than a reproductive mode.

Psychologists Thomas Suddendorf and Michael Corballis gave this capacity a name that has stuck in the literature: **mental time travel** — the ability to mentally project oneself backward to relive, or forward to pre-live, an event. Their comparative work argues this capacity is unusually developed in humans relative to other species, and that its evolutionary value was never really about remembering the past accurately. Remembering evolved, on this account, because it is a serviceable byproduct of a system built to simulate future scenarios — planning a hunt, anticipating a rival, rehearsing a negotiation. The past is a training set. The future is the actual product.

This reframes a question this book will return to repeatedly: when you picture your future clearly, what you are experiencing is not a preview. It is a construction, made of parts borrowed from what you have already lived, assembled by the same engine that quietly rewrites your birthday party every time you recall it. The clarity of the image tells you the engine is running well. It tells you nothing about whether the parts it had available to build with were the right parts.

The Fragment-Availability Problem

If Chapter 1 establishes that the future is built, not previewed, this chapter asks the harder question: built from what, and what happens when the necessary materials were never supplied. Call this the fragment-availability problem — the limiting factor on imagined futures is not willpower, intelligence, or ambition. It is inventory.

2.1 Imagined Futures Are Built Only From Available Past Fragments

A useful real-world illustration comes from research on what psychologists call the **episodic specificity** of future thought. Studies by Roland Benoit and colleagues at the Max Planck Institute found that when subjects were asked to imagine detailed future scenarios, the vividness and specificity of the imagined scene correlated directly with the richness of related past experiences the subject could draw on. Ask someone who has never flown to vividly imagine landing a plane during an emergency, and the imagined scene stays generic — borrowed from film, hearsay, cliché — because there is no first-person fragment set for the engine to recombine. Ask a commercial pilot the same question, and the scene sharpens immediately: instrument readings, specific muscle memory, remembered radio chatter. Same cognitive machinery, radically different raw material.

This is not a claim about intelligence or imagination as talents. It is a claim about inventory. A person raised in an environment where entrepreneurship, or higher education, or international travel were simply never modeled by anyone around them is not failing to imagine those futures out of some deficiency. Their engine has nothing concrete to recombine. The future it generates instead defaults to variations on what it has: familiar roles, familiar ceilings, a plausible next year that looks a great deal like last year. This is exactly the asymmetry named in the Prologue, between a person in a dense, exposed, documented environment and a person in an environment with a narrower, more homogeneous fragment set — not a difference in capability, a difference in supply.

2.2 Why True Novelty Defaults to “Impossible”

The sharper consequence of fragment-availability is what happens at the edge of the inventory, where a genuinely novel outcome would require parts the engine has never held. The mind does

not represent this gap honestly as “no data.” It represents it as a judgment: *unachievable*. The absence of material gets misread as a verdict about reality, when it is actually a report on the engine's supply chain.

A concrete example with real data behind it: economist Raj Chetty's “Opportunity Atlas” research, drawing on tens of millions of anonymized tax records across the United States, found that a child's neighborhood during childhood — not just family income, but the specific streets and social environment — predicted adult income and mobility outcomes with striking precision, even between neighborhoods only a few miles apart. One of the study's most cited findings involves exposure: children who, before age thirteen, moved to a lower-poverty neighborhood showed significantly higher adult earnings than siblings who moved later or not at all. The mechanism researchers point to is not resources alone — it is exposure to a different set of visible, lived outcomes: role models, routines, examples of what a plausible adult life looks like, absorbed early enough to enter the fragment set the prospection engine draws from later.

The Opportunity Atlas data is a structural echo of the Newark-versus-Nagaland framing this book opened with, at a much finer resolution: the gap in projected futures is measurable in tax records, not just felt in conversation, and it moves when fragment exposure moves, even holding material circumstances roughly constant.

This is the hinge the rest of the book turns on. Part II asks what happens when that fragment-limited engine is suddenly, artificially fed fragments that were never locally available — someone else's outcome, transmitted whole, through a network, stripped of the years of friction that actually produced it. The gap does not close when that happens. It becomes visible, and it becomes importable, and those are two very different things from resolving it.

PART II

The Network Variable

Infrastructure Doesn't Create the Gap, It Exposes It

The temptation, raised and set aside in the Preface, is to hand the internet full responsibility for unequal futures. It is a satisfying villain because it is recent, visible, and named. But the fragment-availability problem described in Chapter 2 predates any network technology by centuries. This chapter separates what infrastructure actually does from what it gets blamed for.

3.1 Pre-Network Divergence: Geography, Economy, Kinship

Long before coordination networks existed in any digital sense, fragment sets were already unevenly distributed, and the mechanism was almost purely geographic and economic. Fernand Braudel's work on the Mediterranean world, and later the broader historical literature on pre-industrial mobility, documents populations for whom the entire lived radius — the total set of places, roles, and outcomes a person could actually witness firsthand — rarely extended beyond a day's walk. A peasant in fourteenth-century Languedoc did not fail to imagine becoming a merchant in Genoa for lack of ambition. The fragment simply was not in circulating range. Historian Emmanuel Le Roy Ladurie's microhistory *Montaillou*, reconstructed from Inquisition records of a single French village, shows villagers whose entire vocabulary of possible futures was built from roles they had personally watched played out by people they knew — shepherd, priest, miller, wife. The ceiling on imagination was a ceiling on witnessed inventory, and it existed centuries before a single cable was laid.

Kinship networks performed a related, narrower function: they transmitted fragments vertically, parent to child, but rarely laterally across social distance. A child inherited the fragment set of their household and, at best, their village. This is the baseline the network era did not create — it inherited it.

3.2 What Networks Actually Change: Fragment Access, Not Distance

What digital coordination networks changed is narrower and more mechanical than “connecting the world” suggests: they altered the *rate and resolution* at which fragments cross social distance, without requiring physical proximity, kinship, or shared institution. A useful real-world measure comes from International Telecommunication Union data: global internet penetration rose from under 7% of the world population in the year 2000 to over 65% by the

early 2020s, with mobile broadband reaching rural and low-income regions far faster than any prior communication infrastructure in history, including radio and print. The relevant variable for this book is not the raw connectivity number. It is what that connectivity carries: millions of first-person, high-resolution fragments — a stranger's daily routine, a stranger's home, a stranger's stated income — delivered directly into fragment sets that previously had access only to the household and the village.

Sociologist Manuel Castells, in his work on the network society, described this shift as a move from **space of places** to **space of flows** — social structure increasingly organized around circulating information rather than physical location. Recast in this book's terms: the fragment supply chain stopped being geographically rationed. It is worth being exact about what this does and does not do. It does not close the gap described in Chapter 2 between two people's inventories. It changes where the fragments in each inventory came from — increasingly, from strangers rather than from witnessed local example.

Analogy: think of fragment access before networks as a village well — limited, local, but water you watched drawn and understood the depth of. Network-era fragment access is closer to a municipal water system suddenly connected to every reservoir on the continent — the volume and variety increase enormously, but nothing about the pipe tells you which reservoir any given glass came from, or how deep it actually was to draw.

Imported Futures

Chapter 3 established that networks changed fragment supply lines, not the underlying scarcity mechanism. This chapter examines what happens to the prospection engine described in Chapter 1 when it is fed fragments imported this way — stripped of the friction, time, and failure that actually produced them.

4.1 Seeing Outcome Without Friction

A locally witnessed fragment — watching a neighbor build a business over eight years — arrives bundled with its own cost data: the failed first attempt, the loan, the year with no income, the visible toll on the neighbor's health. An imported fragment, delivered through a network, typically arrives stripped of that bundle. Social media research consistently documents this asymmetry directly. A frequently cited program of studies led by psychologist Philip Verduyn, published in outlets including the *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, found that passive social media consumption — viewing curated outcomes without the surrounding context that produced them — correlated with declines in momentary well-being and increased social comparison, an effect the researchers linked to the one-directional, outcome-only nature of what platforms typically surface.

The mechanism is not that people are shown false information. Individual posts are frequently accurate. The distortion is structural: friction does not compress well into a fifteen-second clip or a single photograph, so it is disproportionately edited out, not through intent but through the format's own constraints. The fragment that reaches the prospection engine is real but incomplete, and the engine, per Chapter 1, has no reliable mechanism for flagging what is missing. It recombines what it received as though it received the whole thing.

4.2 Clarity Mistaken for Proximity

The consequence is a specific, well-documented cognitive error, not a vague cultural mood. Psychologist Daniel Kahneman's **availability heuristic** — the tendency to judge likelihood or ease by how readily an example comes to mind, rather than by its actual base rate — describes exactly the failure mode this chapter is pointing at. A vividly imported outcome, delivered with high sensory resolution and no visible cost, becomes highly *available* to the prospection engine,

and availability gets misread as achievability. The image is easy to generate, so the outcome feels close, even though “easy to generate” and “easy to reach” are entirely different properties, one about the mind's rendering engine, the other about the physical world.

This closes the loop the book opened with: the felt sense that a projected future is achievable “in an instant” is not mysticism and does not require multidimensional consciousness to explain. It is the availability heuristic operating on a fragment supply that networks have made unusually vivid and unusually stripped of cost data. The gap between a Newark trajectory and a Nagaland trajectory, reframed through this chapter, is not a gap in what each person can imagine. Increasingly, both can imagine the same outcome with comparable vividness. It is a gap in which imagined outcome comes bundled with an accurate cost, and which one arrives looking free.

Part III turns from mechanism to consequence: what this asymmetry actually produces when it operates at scale, and — with equal weight — what it does not license anyone to conclude from it.

PART III

Consequences of the Gap

The Asymmetry in Practice

Chapters 1 through 4 built the mechanism piece by piece: prospection is reconstructive, reconstruction depends on fragment inventory, inventory was always unevenly distributed, and networks changed how fragments circulate without closing the underlying gap. This chapter asks what that mechanism produces when two people occupy the same present moment.

5.1 Two Projections, Same Present Moment

Hold two people constant at a single instant, same calendar date, and ask each to project five years forward. Per Chapter 1, both run the same underlying machinery. Per Chapter 2, each draws only on their own fragment inventory. Per Chapter 4, each inventory now likely contains some imported, friction-stripped fragments alongside locally witnessed ones, but in different ratios and from different sources. The two resulting projections are not different in kind — both are honest outputs of the same process — but they are unequal in a specific, measurable sense: one projection is built from a deeper, more cost-accurate inventory than the other, purely as a function of what each person's life has, so far, made available to witness or import.

Economist Sendhil Mullainathan and psychologist Eldar Shafir's research on scarcity, published as *Scarcity: Why Having Too Little Means So Much*, offers a parallel finding at the resource level rather than the fragment level: cognitive bandwidth itself narrows under resource scarcity, so planning and projection get measurably shorter and more present-focused, not from lack of intelligence but from attention consumed by immediate shortfall. Layered onto the fragment-availability mechanism, this suggests the asymmetry compounds rather than merely adding: less fragment inventory to draw on, plus less cognitive bandwidth available to do the drawing, acting on the same person simultaneously.

5.2 Why the Underestimation Runs One Direction

A precise, testable claim follows from Chapter 2.2: the error introduced by fragment scarcity is not symmetric noise. It is directionally biased toward underestimating the achievable, because the engine defaults an unrepresented outcome to “not real” rather than to “unknown.” Chetty's later work with co-authors, including the 2019 study on inventors and “lost Einsteins,” makes this concrete: children with high math ability from low-income families, or from areas with few

local inventors, grew up to patent at dramatically lower rates than equally-talented children from high-income or high-exposure areas — not because of ability, which the study controlled for, but strongly correlated with childhood exposure to inventors in their neighborhood, field, and even gender. The study's authors estimate that if girls, minorities, and children from low-income families invented at the same rate as high-income white men, the innovation rate in the United States would roughly quadruple.

That statistic is the fragment-availability problem expressed at national economic scale: an enormous quantity of achievable futures, foreclosed not by capability but by an inventory the prospection engine was never supplied with early enough for the outcome to register as real rather than fictional.

What This Explains and What It Doesn't

Every mechanism-driven argument accumulates apparent momentum as it runs, and momentum is exactly the point at which a careful argument is most likely to overreach. This closing chapter does two things: it states plainly what the recombination gap is entitled to claim, and it names, explicitly, the one place this book's own reasoning tried to claim more than the mechanism supported.

6.1 Mechanical Claims the Model Supports

Restated without hedging, because each of these was built from a named mechanism and, where possible, real data: prospection is reconstructive, not retrieved, per Bartlett and per Schacter and Addis. Imagined futures are materially limited by fragment inventory, per Benoit's specificity research and per Chetty's Opportunity Atlas findings. That inventory was unevenly distributed long before networks existed, per the pre-industrial mobility record. Networks changed fragment circulation, not the underlying scarcity mechanism, per Castells and ITU connectivity data. Imported fragments arrive disproportionately stripped of cost data, per Verduyn's comparison research. And the resulting error is directionally biased toward underestimating achievable futures, per Chetty's lost-Einsteins findings. Each link in that chain is load-bearing and independently supported. Together they explain, mechanically, why two people at the same moment can hold unequal futures, and why that inequality is not fully explained by material circumstance alone.

6.2 Explicit Boundary: This Is Not a Theory of Meaning

During the construction of this argument, it was pushed, repeatedly and in good faith, toward a further conclusion: that this mechanism explains why existence itself is meaningful — that the very fact of a system capable of referencing its own state across a gap between language and physical reality constitutes a source of meaning. That conclusion does not survive the standard this book set for itself.

The reason is structural, not dismissive. A mechanism that explains a cognitive error — why the achievable gets misjudged as impossible — stays entirely within the domain of what minds get wrong about the world. It says nothing about whether that world, or a life lived in it, carries

value. A thermostat also references and adjusts to its own state relative to a set point; nothing about that feedback loop is generally treated as a source of meaning, and no step in this book's argument supplies a principled reason human self-reference is different in kind rather than only in complexity. Every attempt to bridge that gap turned out, on inspection, to be a separate assertion smuggled in beside the mechanism, not a conclusion the mechanism actually produced.

This boundary is stated formally, so it cannot be quietly re-absorbed in a later reading: the recombination gap is a claim about cognitive error under fragment scarcity. It is not, and does not become, a claim about the meaningfulness of existence. A reader who wants that further claim will need an argument this book does not contain and, on its own terms, is not entitled to borrow.

What remains, held to that boundary, is still a complete and useful account: a description of why futures feel unequal, built from named mechanisms, tested where testable against real data, and stopped precisely where the evidence stopped.

Epilogue

Return to the two people from the Prologue — one in Newark, one on a ridge in Nagaland. Nothing in the six chapters between here and there closes the gap between them. That was never the book's claim to make. What the book offers instead is narrower and, I think, more useful: the gap is not a verdict about either person. It is a description of unequal inventory, run through an identical, well-understood piece of biological machinery.

That reframing matters for a simple, practical reason. A gap attributed to character, culture, or ambition invites judgment, of the self or of the other. A gap attributed to fragment inventory invites a different question: what would it take to supply the missing fragments, deliberately, with the cost data intact, rather than importing them stripped and vivid through a feed. Chetty's lost-Einsteins finding suggests that question is not rhetorical — the quadrupling estimate is a measure of exactly how much is sitting on the other side of it.

This book set out to explain why futures feel unequal, and stopped, deliberately, before claiming to explain what a future is for. That second question was never this book's to answer. It was only ever this book's job to make sure the first answer was honest.

Appendix A

Working Definitions

Prospection — The mental construction of possible future events, using the same reconstructive machinery — hippocampus and default mode network — that the brain uses to recall the past. Not prediction; recombination. (Ch. 1)

Fragment — A discrete, storable unit of lived or witnessed experience — a sensory detail, a role observed, an outcome seen firsthand or imported — that the prospection engine draws on when constructing an imagined future. (Ch. 1–2)

Fragment-Availability Problem — The finding that the specificity and achievability of an imagined future is bounded not by intelligence or ambition but by the size and relevance of the fragment inventory a person has accumulated. (Ch. 2)

Recombination Gap — This book's central term: the structural difference between two people's projected futures, produced by unequal fragment inventories rather than by unequal capability. The book's working thesis and title term. (Ch. 2, 5)

Imported Fragment — A fragment received through a network rather than witnessed directly — typically delivered at high sensory resolution but stripped of the friction, time, and cost data that produced the original outcome. (Ch. 4)

Availability Heuristic — Daniel Kahneman's term for judging likelihood by how easily an example comes to mind rather than by its true base rate; applied in this book to explain why vivid imported fragments feel closer to achievable than they are. (Ch. 4)

Space of Flows — Manuel Castells' term for a social structure increasingly organized around circulating information rather than fixed physical location; used here to describe what networks change about fragment circulation. (Ch. 3)

Connection to Contact Epistemology

This book was produced under the discipline of Contact Epistemology, the broader framework this project operates from: claims are tested against structure and physical or mechanistic consequence, not against how coherent or authoritative they sound — an embodied verification standard rather than an institutional one.

The recombination gap satisfies that standard in the same way Contact Epistemology's central methodological demonstration does elsewhere in the framework: an independent line of reasoning, built from first principles, that arrives at a structure already documented in an established research tradition — in that demonstration's case, a derivation converging with Karl Friston's predictive processing framework, worked through a VTA–nucleus accumbens dopamine mechanism. This book follows the same method: the argument was built from a structural question about unequal futures, and independently arrived at a position that converges with established findings in memory reconstruction (Bartlett, Schacter and Addis), heuristic judgment (Kahneman), and opportunity geography (Chetty). The convergence is the verification. It is what distinguishes a mechanism from a narrative that merely sounds like one.

Where this book differs from a purely narrative account is Chapter 6.2: Contact Epistemology's standard cuts both ways, and it required this project to name and discard its own strongest-sounding but weakest-supported claim, that the mechanism implies something about the meaning of existence. A framework that only ever confirms what it sets out to argue is not applying a standard. This book is offered as one instance of the standard being applied against its own momentum, not only against outside claims.

Notes and Sources

The following works informed the arguments made in each chapter. This is a working bibliography, not a formal citation apparatus; readers seeking primary verification should consult the original studies directly.

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